Papal bulls published by the Catholic Church between 1452 and 1606 ‘permitted the King of Portugal the sole right to sail the sea, to conquer the new lands and extend his dominion at the expense of the Moors and other pagans’. The King of Portugal thus had monopoly over commerce in these regions over other European nations with the threat of excommunication against those who disobeyed. In return, the Portuguese state would construct churches and supply them with priests and protection and thus the Portuguese state and the Catholic Church were bound in an uneasy alliance which had brought the Society of Jesus to the city of Goa.

When Akbar had returned to Fatehpur Sikri after his ecstatic vision of 1578, he had entered into the debates of the ibadat khana with renewed enthusiasm and energy. But to his desolation and bemusement the debates between the mullahs and theologians again descended into vile abuse. ‘The antagonism of the sects reached such a pitch,’ revealed a disappointed Badauni, ‘that they would call one another fools and heretics.’ The attacks became personal with Abdullah Sultanpuri accusing Abd un-Nabi of being undutiful towards his father, as well as afflicted with hemorrhoids, while Abd un-Nabi’s response was to call him a fool. Severely disappointed with the arrogance of the theologians, men he had once been in thrall to, Akbar now put forward before them an articulate, erudite, and driven young man, who would have burned with the sharp memory of his father’s humiliation and debasement at the hands of these very men. ‘The Emperor,’ agreed Badauni, ‘expected to find in Abu’l Fazl a man capable of teaching the Mullahs a lesson.’ These men had hounded Shaikh Mubarak mercilessly for twenty years and had even tried to have him executed. In an earlier time they had succeeded in having Shaikh Alai, a friend of Shaikh Mubarak, flogged and tortured to death under Islam Shah Sur on charges of being a Mahdavi. Now Abu’l Fazl, using his wit and his wide erudition, could expose the ulema for the opinionated, opportunistic, and corrupt men that they were. However, when he did as expected, Badauni lamented that Abu’l Fazl indeed ‘took every opportunity of reviling in the most shameful way’ the sadr and the makhdum ul-mulk, Abdullah Sultanpuri, because of which ‘miseries and misfortunes broke in upon the ulema’. When these men were brought low, Abu’l Fazl was wont to quote the following quatrain, which he claimed applied to them perfectly:

I have set fire to my barn with my own hands,
As I am the incendiary, how can I complain of my enemy!